of monies would be final at a time of a once-in-a-century crisis was perhaps the driving force behind establishing PM CARES. Moreover, PM CARES was designed to live up to the test of time as it would pass on to the incumbent governments over years to come versus continuing to being managed by one particular political party and its chosen few as in the case of PMNRF.

However, the media noise was so dichotomous that the real intent behind the formation of PM CARES barely came through. However, despite the unnecessary ruckus, contributions to the fund continued to be made generously by Indians—a sign in the truest sense that India placed immense faith in the prime minister's integrity. Moreover, a public interest petition filed in the Supreme Court to transfer the funds collected in PM CARES to the National Disaster Response Fund was dismissed by a three-judge Bench which also noted that 'financial planning was the government's prerogative' and 'no one could question it'.[31]

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Several relaxations in the usual tendering processes for building of standalone COVID-19-treatment centres and procurement of medical and necessary equipment to maintain and run these centres were made at the state and city corporation levels. Due to these relaxations, several instances of corruption surfaced where large sums were given out to preferred vendors and builders. For instance, in Mumbai, the MCGM, the richest corporation in Asia, spent over ₹1,200 crore to erect and manage 'Jumbo COVID-19 Centres' from March to December 2020. Due to the time sensitivity, several relaxations in due processes were made and allegations have since surfaced over favours given out by the ruling party, Shiv Sena, to private builders without inviting tenders.[32] Adding fuel to the fire, the MCGM chief was unceremoniously transferred in the middle of a nationwide lockdown.[33] After demands from the opposition party to audit the funds, the MCGM set up a standing committee for the purpose of investigating corruption charges. It remains to be seen if such a body can evaluate itself fairly! If the audit was intended to be fair, an external committee with members of all parties and ex-bureaucrats should have been set up.